Signs of stress



Headaches, tiredness, changes in sleep or appetite



Fear, sadness, anger, or feeling numb



Less motivation, trouble concentrating, using more alcohol or tobacco, pulling away from colleagues or family

The person under stress is often the last to notice. Colleagues can help each other see it.

Ask for help early

Stress getting worse, not going away, or making work and daily life hard? Talk to your supervisor or a health worker. Asking early is good practice.

Get help now

In danger, or thinking of harming yourself? Get help now. Ask a health worker or responder, and ask someone you trust to stay with you.

Support for staff and volunteers: _____
(filled in and checked locally)

Look after yourself.
Look after each other.

Support is for everyone, including people with disabilities and older people. Ask for large print or more time.

Adapted from IASC, Basic Psychosocial Skills: A Guide for COVID-19 Responders (2020), CC BY-NC-SA 3.0 IGO, and IFRC Psychosocial Centre, Caring for Volunteers. This adaptation was not created by the IASC or IFRC, which are not responsible for its content. Licence of this adaptation: CC BY-NC-SA 3.0 IGO.

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FOR PEOPLE WHO HELP OTHERS

Looking after yourself is part of looking after others

Helping people after a distressing experience is meaningful work, and it is also tiring. Stress is a common reaction among people who help others. You cannot take care of others for long if you do not take care of yourself.







1 Every day

- Rest and sleep when you can, and eat regular meals
- Take short breaks during the day
- Keep in touch with family and friends
- Talk with a colleague or someone you trust for a few minutes each day
- Do something you enjoy or find meaningful
- Focus on what you can control; let go of what you cannot
- Try slow breathing to calm down
- In the evening, notice one way you helped someone today

2 Look out for each other

Work in pairs where you can, and check on each other. Suggest a break when a colleague looks tired. New team members can be paired with someone more experienced.

After a very difficult day or event

Stay with a colleague who is upset. Listen without judging, and accept their feelings. Offer practical help: a quiet place, food, water, contact with their family. Nobody has to talk about what happened if they do not want to.

3 Ways of coping that can make things worse

- ✕ Drinking more alcohol or using drugs
- ✕ Working without breaks or days off
- ✕ Keeping everything to yourself for a long time

📖 For health workers: Self-care of health workers during floods and disasters (NHEICC).

Where to find support

Your supervisor or team leader · A colleague you trust · Staff support: _____ (filled in locally)